

Indian Literary Theory

Kavyasastra

“The unexamined life is not worth living.”

Socrates (470-399 BC)

- Introspection / Self-reflection
 - Critical thinking: questioning one's beliefs, actions and purpose
 - Logical argument
 - Wisdom
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- Therefore, a life without philosophy is not worth living.

(Brihadaranyaka Upanishad, 7-6 c BCE)

“Atma va are drastavyaha”

“See the self”

Aitareya Brahmana 6.27 (Rig Veda circa 1000 BC)

“The arts are refinement of the self (*atma-samskriti*). With these the worshipper recreates his self that is made of rhythms, meters.”

Requisites

- Literature
- Philosophy
- Art and Aesthetics
- History
- Poetry
- Interpretative skills
- Language skills

A Liberal Arts attitude

- Learning a subject for its own sake
- Academic approach: **knowledge systems** stemming from circumstances: past intellectual history, paradigm shifts, revolutions
- Freedom from personal and community prejudices
- Eudaimonia or flourishing
- Arts versus entertainment
- Aesthetic susceptibility / surrender to the poem
- Sahridaya / universal heart / connoisseur

Instructor background

Where am I coming from?

British literature

American literature

European literature

Black Literature

Indian English literature

Assamese literature / Bhasa literature

What was I not taught in college / university?

- Classical and Medieval Indian literature: both texts and theories
- Bhasha literature
- Dalit and other marginalised literatures: both texts and theories
- Folk literatures of India

Instructor approach: Academic

Peer-reviewed

Gate-keeping

Reason

Argumentation

Evidence-based

Unpacking the course title

- Indian: problematic yet a shared **symbolic universe**, set of beliefs often with little scientific validity, yet immensely powerful psychologically
- A **geographical and cultural signifier** or identifier
- Indus civilization
- Sindhu to Hindu
- **Our journey: From ancient and medieval Sanskrit to contemporary Dalit theories**

Organization: two opposite discourses

Sanskritic

Dalit

Sanskrit (elite) ----- Pali and Prakrit (apabhramsa) -----
Persian influence (Hindustani / Urdu) ----- Bhashas resistance
----- Dalit resistance

Literary Theory

- A **systematic** inquiry into the following:
- The **nature** of literature
- **Methods** used for analyzing literary texts
- **Interdisciplinary**: philosophy, history, political science, linguistics, sociology, psychology, digital studies, computer sciences, medical sciences and others
- **System**, body of knowledge with dedicated practitioners
- **Schools** / *gharanas* with their own beliefs, styles, methods of approaching literary texts.

Examples of schools of literary theory (Western)

- Textual Studies (stylistics)
- Liberal Humanism
- Marxism
- Feminism
- Structuralism and Poststructuralism
- Modernism and Postmodernism
- Postcolonialism
- Cultural Studies

6 major Indian literary theories: Classical and Medieval

- Rasa: Aesthetic relish (psycho-physical response)
- Dhvani: Suggestion
- Alankara: Ornamentation
- Vakrokti: Obliquity of expression
- Aucitya: Propriety
- Riti: Style

Can you spot the major difference?

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Textual Studies (stylistics)
Liberal Humanism
Marxism
Feminism
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The Arts in Ancient India

- | | |
|-------------|----------------|
| • Truth | Emotions |
| • Value | Pleasure |
| • Judgment | Beauty |
| • Elegance | Creativity |
| • Form | Authenticity |
| • Structure | Representation |
| • Style | Craft |
| • Taste | Imagination |
| | Morality |
| | Knowledge |

Qualities of good poetry

- Abhijatya or classicality
- Saubhagya or splendour
- Lavanya or grace
- Prasada or clarity
- Madhurya or sweetness
- Aucitya or propriety

Kavyasastra

- Kavya: all creative literature, not only poems
- All texts were written in verse form, including scientific texts
- Mahakavya: long poems, epics like the *Mahabharata*
- Akhyan: narratives
- Sutra: coded, aphoristic texts like *Vaisesika Sutra*
- Sukta: hymns marked by beauty, like the Nasadiya Sukta, *Rig Veda*

Shilpa Sastra: Art / Kala / Shilpa

- art, skill, craft, labor, ingenuity, rite and ritual, form and creation

Chausath Kala or the 64 arts

- **Geet vidya:** art of singing.
- **Vadya vidya:** art of playing on musical instruments.
- **Nritya vidya:** art of dancing.
- **Natya vidya:** art of theatricals.
- **Alekhya vidya:** art of painting.
- **Viseshakacchedya vidya:** art of painting the face and body with color

Sastra: from Sasana meaning instruction

- Manual, compendium of rules, technical or specialized knowledge
- Bhautikasastra: Physics
- Jivasastra: Biology
- Natyasastra: Theatre
- Silpasastra: Crafts
- Vastysastra: Architecture
- Kamasastra: Desire

Not didactic or strict

- The *Dharmasastras* are tolerant
 - May present ideals of behaviour
 - Accommodate diverse views
 - Likely human failings
 - Prayaschit
-
- Apatdharma : emergency